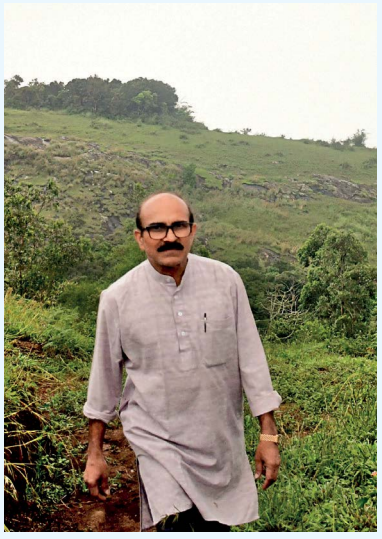


GREEN MISSION
Shola grasslands in Idukki's high ranges; Prof. Johnykutty at his nature park, Hill 7



HRISHI RAJENDRAN

ARRIOR'S PATH

Kerala...in some four decades, we have transformed the place into a wasteland," says Dr Sajeed A., additional director at the Regional Cancer Centre, Thiruvananthapuram and an enthusiastic naturalist. "It's alright to support tourism and plantations, but the shola lands have disappeared altogether, and nobody bothered to protest. I used to come here once a month with my family, but it's not the same anymore," he says wistfully.

Mankuttimedu and adjoining areas are also a 'cloud forest' zone, feeding off the moisture generated by the high ranges. But now an "ecological tension" has taken root in a region once known as a 'green wall' in the Western Ghats. "I belong to the third generation of settlers in the area," says the 62-year-old Johnykutty. "My grandfather first came and settled here and we were born and educated here. I have lived all my life here and worked as a lecturer of physics at the MES College in Nedumkandam, just a few kilometres away, for almost 32 years. The environmental degradation has happened before my eyes, which was the main reason I decided to set up the nature park."

The professor's passion also inspired him to get a doctorate in Environmental Sciences. Kerala has 11,309 sq. km of forests, of which 9,107 sq. km is reserve forest, another 364 sq. km form part of proposed reserves and 1,837 sq. km is vested forest. Of the total 5,019 sq. km that makes up Idukki, 3,155 sq. km is forest land, the largest slice of green cover among all 14 districts in the state. Data from the environmental agency Global Forest Watch reveals that the district has lost 115 sq. km of tree cover in the past two decades, a nearly 3 per cent drop since the turn of the century.

The cardamom hill reserve in Udumbanchola taluk in Idukki has witnessed the most damage, with plantation area now extending to 1,317 sq. km, up almost 1,000 sq. km in the past three decades. The tourism lobby, land mafia and political parties have all played a part in this mindless destruction. Johnykutty says his efforts are a "penance" for the damage done by early settlers, including his grandfather. "I kept the land idle and built water storage systems so that the natural vegetation could regenerate. After 25 years, the grassland and trees have recovered," he explains.

DATA SHOWS IDUKKI DISTRICT HAS LOST 115 SQ. KM OF TREE COVER IN THE PAST TWO DECADES, A 3% DROP SINCE THE TURN OF THE CENTURY

Hill 7 also offers nature camps and tours with tented accommodation and food and is a hit with researchers too. Megha Majoe, a 29-year-old whose field of study is myrmecology (the study of ants), feels right at home. "The misty mountains and the rich biodiversity fill my heart with great positive energy," she says.

Kerala's green spaces are shrinking, but the situation is especially daunting in the hills. Revenue officials in Idukki, though, say there are some positives. The district task force has apparently evicted encroachers and reclaimed 229 acres of land in Devikulam and Udumbanchola taluks. But it's an uphill task. "It's not easy to evict encroachments in Idukki. People are educated and they approach the courts for a stay on evictions or use other legal options to encroach on virgin forests, often with the support of government officials. The 2018 floods and the effects of climate change in the past few years should have taught us a lesson, but few are taking heed," a revenue official in Idukki told INDIA TODAY.

He cites the example of hill station Ooty to show how things can go wrong. Once a paradise of virgin shola forests, excessive tourism and construction have ruined it. Something similar is happening in Munnar and Wayanad in Kerala, with weekends seeing traffic jams for miles in the hills. Thanks to high court interventions and action taken by a few forest and revenue officials, fresh land encroachments are down. But Kerala will have to do a lot more if it wants to remain a country the gods are partial to. ■